

## Stars and Swipes



"I stared as one—and then the other—of the twin towers of New York's World Trade Centre collapsed. And then I smiled. Yes, despicable as it may sound, my initial reaction was to be remarkably pleased." This is Changez, the narrator of Mohsin Hamid's

Booker-shortlisted *The Reluctant Fundamentalist*. This young Pakistani immigrant, an Ivy League topper, is a posh professional in Manhattan, cozily trapped in the great American dream. When someone brought America to "her knees", the awesome symbolism of it made him happy. Elsewhere, beyond the pages of fiction, others too, in varying degrees of perversion, might have smiled as justice hit the Evil Imperium. It was unlikely that the sentiment of *Le Monde* on 9/11—"We are all Americans today"—was echoed across the Middle Eastern ghettos. Pre-9/11, anti-Americanism, to a large extent, was a Cold War leftover, and a bestseller in the so-called Third World. Sustained by cause junkies as diverse as the romantics of Palestine and the street fighters of Seattle, this ism raged against the transgressions of American freedom—or the excess of idealism. And for those who were orphaned by the fall of the Soviet Union, the expansion of an idea called America seemed all the more frightening without the comfort of a counterpoint.

India was one of those "third world" sanctuaries where anti-Americanism flourished with some kind of establishment patronage—yes, long before Prakash Karat. In an India where the ruling class was adequately schooled in Sovietology, anti-Americanism was a credo that was in perfect harmony with the official socialist mindset. Even in a world united by the debris of the Berlin Wall, India refused to break out of Third Worldism. We were still eulogising the nonsensical non-alignment as nations were realigning in a brash new world. Atal Bihari Vajpayee broke the mould; India and America began a conversation. We were on the right side of history, and it was a redeeming shift dictated by national interest. Today, courtesy Karat and other desperate revolutionaries who badly need an enemy, evil in stars and stripes is out there in the street. It is a phantom. It keeps alive sloganeers who are left with no heroes—there is not even a Saddam Hussain—but only the villain. In a country like India this villain appeals only to those who live in the lies of an ideology. Our civil society has already made anti-Americanism redundant.



SAURABH SINGH

## SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

### "I was never a puppet in BCCI"

FORMER CRICKET CAPTAIN KAPIL DEV SPOKE TO EDITOR PRABHU CHAWLA about the ICL and the future of Indian cricket

**Q. Why are you fighting with BCCI?**

A. I'm not fighting with the players. I'm fighting for our cricketers. I'm not against any player.

**Q. Why did you form the Indian Cricket League (ICL)?**

A. We felt a lot still needed to be done for cricket. There's a lot of scope for cricket in India. We want to contribute to its growth.

**Q. Didn't BCCI encourage you in becoming a great cricketer?**

A. I'm thankful to them but I have always played for myself and my country. Today I'm fighting for those cricketers who don't have any work.

**Q. Are you doing this only for money?**

A. Sport is a job. Is it wrong to earn money for your work? If it's wrong, then we're doing a wrong thing.

**Q. What are the main objectives of ICL?**

A. We want to give a new lease of life to our players. A cricketer's career is very short. You can't retire a player at the age of 35.

**Q. Is ICL a non-profit organisation?**

A. I don't know. I am not the owner of the ICL. I don't want to take money from our future players.

**Q. Did Sharad Pawar call you for a meeting?**

A. No, he didn't call me. I went to meet him as a cricketer, not as an ICL official. I asked him to take the formation of ICL positively.

**Q. What about I.S. Bindra's allegations?**

A. He is not speaking the truth. We met at the Delhi Golf Club but it was not an official meeting. I was never a puppet in his hands, not even when he was the chairman of the BCCI.

**Q. Did you give your suggestions to BCCI before quitting?**

A. I did not leave BCCI. They sacked me. I had suggested to them that they recognise all former cricketers and to form a national academy at Bangalore. But the BCCI rejected my advice.

**Q. Will ICL distribute its profits among players?**

A. We haven't decided yet. Subhash Chandra Goyal has invested a lot of money. We have just started our journey. We want to work for the welfare of our cricketers.

**Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday**

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>



SIPRA DAS